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When I think of Varleen Biketi, the word exemplary first comes to mind. From the input she gave in lessons, her interactions with other students in the class, to her excellent academic performance, she added a rare, invaluable component to my Geography class. If I had to pick just one outstanding student in all the years I have taught, it would be her.

Varleen has shown resilience through the Geography class. In her first year, she was performing reasonably well, and it seemed that she was comfortable with the subject. However, when the time came to select subjects in form 2 (10th grade), Varleen was uncertain about continuing with geography. She privately told me that though she loved the subject, she could not proceed because of the difficulty in grasping concepts with increasing study volume. After several consultations, I convinced her to take the subject with tutor aid from a student in a higher class. She was in a group of three students I had placed in the program. Varleen showed tremendous growth in the group. In the first few tests I issued, she performed very poorly, but this turned into a driving force to attend more tutoring sessions. They would finish tests and turn them in together, coming for further consultation as a group. In fact, after about three months, they no longer needed a tutor. This reflected on exams as Varleen was among the top in her Geography class, improving from scoring 50% in tests to above 85% in school exams. She is the precise definition of success through teamwork.

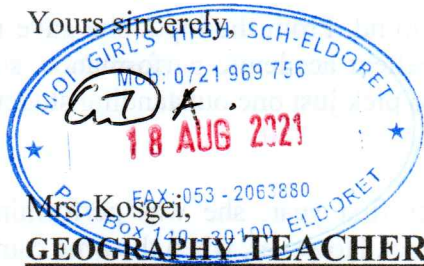
Varleen practically applied concepts taught in class. When I taught about weathering and mass wasting, Varleen asked me follow-up questions after the lesson on the primary triggers of mass wasting in the school's region and whether the soil type had a crucial role in this. I gave her a very detailed answer to the best of my ability, but she went on further to ask for any books I would suggest for further information. Later in the week, she came to my office requesting permission for her class to conduct a fieldwork study around the school to identify the major causes of mass wasting based on the soil type. She clearly stated the chemical composition of the soil, both organic and inorganic, giving evidence that she had done further study in that area, out of what their syllabus required. Together with her class, after their survey, Varleen concluded that the silt-sized soil particles around their dorms were the main reason causing the blockage of their drainages. With the assistance of the school workshop, they installed silt fences and dug out silt from the drainage as a class. Whenever I teach a class on mass wasting, I always refer to her silt fences. Varleen left a legacy, and students coming after her are learning a great deal from her initiative.

Varleen has proven to take a proactive stance when it comes to academics. When the Covid-19 pandemic broke out in March, we had to shut down the school and only resumed learning after a seven-month break. The school did not continue with lessons online, and as a result, in the Geography department, we were behind six topics with just three months until their national examination. I was worried about my class because I was forced to rush the syllabus, whether or not the students kept up with me. However, Varleen took the responsibility of her class to herself. Rallying about three more students from her class,

they divided the topics among themselves, which they would take turns teaching the rest of the course. She would periodically, with the three other students, consult me on various subtopics, most of which were about the formation of limestone features, glaciation, and climate in different regions in Kenya. Our class average in Geography rose from a 7.6 in the midterm exam to a 9.3 out of 12 in the end term because of their efforts. When other teachers in the staff room asked me the secret to the excellent performance of my Geography class, my answer was constant; it was because of the willpower of one student that all became successful. Students like her are a reminder of the reason I became a teacher in the first place.

When Varleen's four years in high school were done, I wished to turn back the clock to her first year and teach her all over again, watching her evolve into the distinguished student she is now. I am looking forward to getting word of the great things she will accomplish at your institution. All the best to her!

Yours sincerely,



Mrs. Kosgei,

GEOGRAPHY TEACHER